Private messages can leak without being read

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The problem

Mafia messages reached the right players. But a Town player could watch server threads and infer which connections received them.

One controlled Mafia-chat window



Highlighted IDs = active connections

Public joins mapped threads to players. The observer never received the Mafia text.

The change

Protected startup is the default. Separate Linux accounts and hidepid=2 block access to the server metadata used by this test.

```
sudo ./server --players 5
```

Resource limits per player account

25% of one CPU

256 MiB hard memory cap

64 tasks

Other players' cgroup statistics are restricted too.

The result

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Baseline windows matched expected recipients, including idle controls.

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Protected windows: the required metadata was unavailable.

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After visibility was re-enabled, the inference matched again.

Protect while playing. Restore when finished.

Shutdown restores prior settings. Forced-kill recovery uses --restore.

Resource tests throttled CPU, blocked forks, and killed the memory stressor. The game finished.

Hard-memory test: the 192 MiB soft throttle was temporarily disabled inside the test VM.

Controlled quiet-window tests, November 12, 2026. This blocks the measured channel; it does not prove every side channel is gone.

I learned to protect activity as well as message contents.